Civic Debate Academy

Brand Guidelines

VERSION

01

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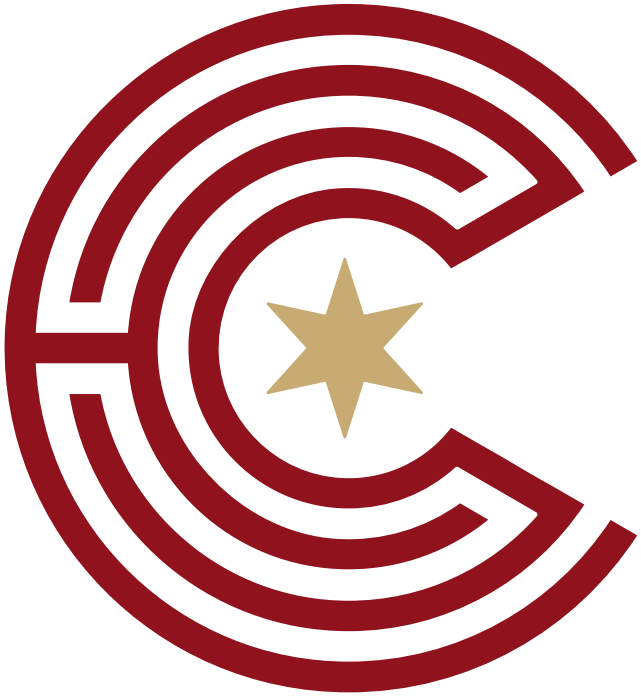

1.1 Logomark

The Civic Debate Academy logomark features a stylized “C” shaped as a labyrinth, symbolizing the intellectual journey at the heart of debate — from complexity to clarity. The maze reflects the rigorous, critical thinking process that defines CDA’s approach to education, while also serving as a subtle evolution of the academy’s previous logo, honoring its growth.

Nestled within the center of the “C” is a six-pointed star, a subtle but intentional nod to CDA’s Chicago roots, grounding the brand in its origin while projecting upward mobility. Together, the labyrinth and star form a unique and memorable mark that blends intellect, place, and progress, serving as a modern emblem of the academy’s mission to shape articulate, thoughtful leaders.

HORIZONTAL

Civic Debate Academy

VERTICAL

Civic Debate Academy

1.2 Primary Logo

The primary logo combines the Civic Debate Academy logomark with the academy's full name typeset in Neulis Sans, a contemporary sans-serif typeface chosen for its clarity, geometric precision, and subtle warmth. The result is a lockup that balances intellectual rigor with approachability, reinforcing CDA's identity as both elite and student-focused.

This horizontal configuration is the preferred version for most applications, including the website header, official documents, digital marketing, and branded merchandise. It creates strong brand recognition by pairing the distinctiveness of the labyrinth-style "C" with the six-pointed star and the clean, modern presentation of the academy name.

Usage tip: Use the full-color logo on light or neutral backgrounds for best contrast. Monochrome and inverted versions are available for darker or photographic backgrounds.

CIVIC DEBATE ACADEMY

CDA | DEBATE

1.3 Secondary Logo

The secondary logo features a custom “CDA” letterform built into the shape of a solvable maze, further reinforcing the brand’s core metaphor: navigating complexity with clarity and precision. In this variation, the six-pointed star is cleverly integrated into the crossbar of the “A”, serving as both a visual anchor and a subtle nod to CDA’s Chicago heritage. This mark is designed to be bold, adaptable, and highly recognizable — ideal for more compact or informal brand applications such as apparel, social media avatars, certificates, and promotional items.

A modular version of this logo includes the word “DEBATE” to the right of the maze monogram, which can be swapped out to reflect the full range of CDA’s academic offerings. This flexibility allows the brand to maintain a consistent visual identity across its sub-brands — such as “MATH,” “TEST PREP,” or “ADVISING” — while clearly signaling the specific service being offered.

Usage tip:: Use the standalone CSA maze mark when space is limited. Use the modular word extension to identify sub-brands across programs and print materials.

1.4 Brand Seal

The Civic Debate Academy seal is a formal variation of the logomark, designed for use on official documents, certificates, awards, and ceremonial materials. It places the maze-style “C” and six-pointed star at the center of a circular badge, creating a mark that conveys tradition, authority, and academic prestige.

The circular format evokes the feel of institutional seals used by universities and scholarly organizations, while maintaining the modern and intentional design language of the CDA brand. The seal should be used sparingly and exclusively in contexts that require a more formal or commemorative tone.

Usage tip: Do not substitute the seal for the primary logo in everyday applications. Reserve for certificates of completion, academic honors, official transcripts, or institutional documents.

1.5 Reversed & Grayscale Version

To maintain clarity and visual integrity across all applications, the Civic Debate Academy logo system includes reversed and grayscale versions for use in specific contexts.

Reversed Logo

The reversed logo is designed for use on dark or colored backgrounds, where the standard full-color logo would lose legibility. In this variation, the logomark and wordmark are presented in white or light neutral tones, ensuring strong contrast and readability.

Use the reversed logo when:

- Placing the logo on dark navy, black, red, or photographic backgrounds
- Creating high-contrast digital or print materials (e.g., banners, overlays, apparel)

Grayscale Logo

The grayscale version is intended for black-and-white print applications or situations where full-color production is not available. It retains the structural integrity of the logo while ensuring it remains professional and legible.

Use the grayscale logo when:

- Producing documents in black-and-white (e.g., faxes, forms, some internal materials)
- Using laser or budget printing where color cannot be guaranteed
- Creating embossed, engraved, or single-tone print materials

Avoid:

- Using grayscale on digital platforms or primary marketing materials
- Applying either version to backgrounds with insufficient contrast

1.6 Clear Space

To preserve the visual integrity and impact of the Civic Debate Academy logo, a minimum clear space must be maintained around the logo at all times. This ensures the logo remains legible, uncluttered, and visually distinct in all applications.

The required clear space is defined by the height of the capital "C" in the wordmark. This measurement — referred to as "1C" — should be used as a buffer on all sides of the logo, including top, bottom, left, and right.

Nothing should encroach within this space — including text, images, borders, or other design elements.

This standard applies to all variations of the logo, including the primary lockup, the secondary modular mark, and the seal.

1.7 Minimum Size

To maintain legibility and visual clarity, the Civic Debate Academy logo should never be reproduced below the minimum size thresholds outlined below. Reducing the logo too far compromises readability, especially for the maze and star details in the logomark.

Horizontal Logo (Primary)

Minimum Height: 0.5 inches (or 36 pixels for digital use)

Ideal for headers, documents, and digital interfaces where horizontal space is available.

Vertical / Stacked Logo (Secondary)

Minimum Height: 1 inch (or 72 pixels for digital use)

Use when vertical layout is preferred, such as on merchandise, social media, or certificates.

Note: These minimums apply to the height of the entire logo lockup — not just the logomark.

Always scale logos proportionally. Do not manually stretch or compress.

1.8 Incorrect Usage

To maintain the consistency and professionalism of the Civic Debate Academy brand, the logo must never be altered or distorted. Below are common misuses that should be strictly avoided in all applications:

Stretching or Warping

Altering Colors

Placing in Low-Contrast

Adding Extra Effects

Changing the Font

Rotating

2.1 Structure

All sub-brands follow this format:

CDA: [Sub-Brand Name]

(E.g., CDA: Math Instruction)

2.2 Sub-Brands List & Descriptions

Sub-Brand	Description
CDA: Advising	Support for academic planning, course selection, and long-term student strategy
CDA: Math	Individual and group-based instruction in core math subjects, logic, and problem solving
CDA: Test Prep	ACT, SAT, PSAT and more — results-driven strategies and customized prep
CDA: College Prep	Essay coaching, application strategy, school selection
CDA: English	ESL, creative writing, language arts fundamentals, and academic writing support

2.3 Visual Treatment

The visual treatment of the Civic Debate Academy brand should strike a confident balance between modern clarity and academic prestige. The brand's look is intentionally clean and structured, with thoughtful use of space, hierarchy, and contrast to reflect the values of rigor, accessibility, and excellence.

Visual assets should incorporate:

- **Minimalist layouts** with generous white space to communicate clarity and focus
- **Strong, anchored typography** that mirrors our commitment to structure and logic
- **Deliberate use of colo**r — with Debate Red as the primary voice and Scholar's Gold as a refined accent to highlight achievement or prestige
- **Subtle maze-inspired motifs** or linear elements to nod to the journey of critical thinking and discovery
- **Photography and illustration styles** (where used) should feel smart, dynamic, and aspirational — never stiff or overly corporate

Consistency in visual treatment strengthens brand recognition and builds trust across every touchpoint, from digital banners to printed certificates.

Civic Debate Academy should feel like the intersection of the Ivy League and the incubator — elevated, smart, and just a little disruptive.

CDA | ADVISING

CDA | COLLEGE PREP

CDA | MATH

CDA | TEST PREP

CDA | ENGLISH

3.1 Primary Colors

Civic Debate Academy's primary color palette reflects the brand's balance of intellectual rigor, leadership, and refined excellence. These two foundational colors — Crimson and Gold — are used consistently across all core communications, marketing materials, and branded assets.

These colors evoke the emotional and institutional strength of legacy academies while signaling CDA's modern, high-performing identity.

CRIMSON

HEX: #8E121C

CMYK: C: 20 M: 100 Y: 92 K: 15

This bold, commanding red is the heart of CDA's brand. It communicates confidence, determination, and intensity, reinforcing the academy's position as a national leader in debate and critical thinking education. Use this as a primary accent for calls to action, headers, badges, and key visual elements.

SCHOLAR GOLD

HEX: #C8AA72

CMYK: C: 20 M: 30 Y: 65 K: 10

The gold accent adds a layer of elegance, prestige, and academic tradition. It should be used sparingly — to highlight, elevate, and distinguish important elements such as awards, certificates, or navigation accents. When used with deep hues (such as charcoal or sub-brand colors), it enhances clarity and sophistication.

3.2 Sub-Brand Colors

To reflect the breadth of Civic Debate Academy's academic offerings while maintaining a unified brand voice, each sub-brand is given its own signature deep tone. These hues were selected to evoke the essence of each discipline through the lens of intellect, sophistication, and clarity.

Each sub-brand color is designed to pair seamlessly with Scholar Gold—creating visual harmony across all communications, whether on the web, in print, or in physical environments.

MIDNIGHT BLUEPRINT | ADVISING

A deep, thoughtful blue that suggests guidance, structure, and clarity of vision.

HEX: #09264B

CMYK: 78, 51, 0, 75

IRON VIOLET | TEST PREP

A rich plum with depth and edge, symbolizing readiness, challenge, and competitive excellence.

HEX: #39244D

CMYK: 65, 76, 13, 60

ESPRESSO | COLLEGE PREP

A deep espresso-brown that blends academic seriousness with warmth and maturity.

HEX: #5E4C46

CMYK: 0, 21, 22, 77

DEEP GROVE | ENGLISH

An earthy green-black that evokes fluency, depth of language, and reflective thinking.

HEX: #28573B

CMYK: 55, 0, 60, 70

MODERN TEAL | MATH

Sharp and sophisticated — reflects precision and analytical thinking.

HEX: #005F74

CMYK: 100, 0, 16, 57

3.3 Secondary Colors - Neutral

To provide greater flexibility across print, digital, and environmental applications, a supporting palette of neutral and tonal colors has been selected. These secondary hues ensure consistency across design elements such as backgrounds, dividers, typography, and subtle highlights—without overwhelming the bold character of the primary or sub-brand colors.

DEBATE CHARCOAL

HEX: #410500
CMYK: 0, 74, 62, 89

IVORY LEDGER

HEX: #FAF4F3
CMYK: 1, 3, 2, 0

STONE GRAY

HEX: #928579
CMYK: 0, 10, 19, 51

PARCHMENT MIST

HEX: #F0E4D0
CMYK: 5, 8, 18, 0

SLATE INK

HEX: #605F6E
CMYK: 17, 17, 0 66

3.4 Secondary Colors - Highlights

Use sparingly for buttons, hover states, infographics, or emphasis in social/digital content.
These create contrast without overwhelming your core palette.

CIVIC BLUE

HEX: #006DAE
CMYK: 87, 49, 0, 9

VERDANT MINT

HEX: #7DBCB1
CMYK: 45, 0, 28, 11

SUNLIT CORAL

HEX: #F26A48
CMYK: 0, 73, 76, 9

CIVIC VIOLET

HEX: #AA85B3
CMYK: 27, 47, 0, 9

GOLDENROD LIGHT

HEX: #F2C97A
CMYK: 0, 17, 58, 5

Usage Guidance:

- Use no more than two accent colors per layout to maintain visual balance.
- Civic Blue and Goldenrod Light can echo your brand's academic seriousness while still modernizing it.
- These colors are also ADA-compliant when paired correctly with your primary neutrals.

4.1 Primary Font Family

Typography is one of the most distinctive and consistent tools for expressing a brand's personality. For Civic Debate Academy, the Neulis Sans type family has been chosen to convey modernity, precision, and intellectual approachability.

Neulis Sans is a humanist sans-serif with subtle warmth and clarity, ideal for communicating both academic excellence and contemporary relevance. Its geometric structure mirrors the logic and discipline of debate, while its soft curves and openness give it an accessible, human touch — reflecting the supportive, student-centered ethos of the Academy.

NEULIS SANS BOLD

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

NEULIS SANS MEDIUM

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

NEULIS SANS REGULAR

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

NEULIS SANS LIGHT

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

4.2 Font Heirarchy

To maintain a clean and cohesive visual identity, Civic Scholars Academy uses a clear typographic hierarchy based on the Neulis Sans type family. This hierarchy ensures consistent communication across digital, print, and environmental applications, enhancing readability while reinforcing the brand's tone and professionalism.

H1:
NEULIS SANS BOLD

Headline Font

H2:
NEULIS SANS MEDIUM

Subheadline goes right here

BODY COPY:
NEULIS SANS REGULAR

Body Copy

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Donec purus tortor, venenatis id nisi non, dignissim egestas ligula. Praesent scelerisque, libero sed lobortis efficitur, mauris nunc maximus purus, id faucibus mi elit vel tellus. Nullam nec vehicula odio, ut rhoncus nulla. Praesent scelerisque ex quis ligula ultricies, quis vulputate nunc volutpat. Ut ornare erat a tellus accumsan sollicitudin. Praesent sit amet urna odio. Nulla at rutrum ex. Nulla molestie neque mi, in pretium ipsum mattis eu. Suspendisse bibendum ipsum ac malesuada scelerisque. Sed gravida ante quis leo eleifend ullamcorper.

CAPTIONS:
NEULIS SANS LIGHT

Captions and metadata copy looks like this

4.3 Web-Safe Alternative

To ensure consistency and performance across all digital platforms, Civic Scholars Academy uses Montserrat as the web-safe alternative to Neulis Sans.

Montserrat is a modern, geometric sans-serif typeface that aligns closely with the visual tone of Neulis Sans. With strong legibility and wide browser support, Montserrat ensures brand fidelity across various screen sizes, email clients, and web environments where custom fonts may not be supported.

MONTSERRAT BOLD

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

MONTSERRAT MEDIUM

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

MONTSERRAT REGULAR

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

MONTSERRAT LIGHT

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz1234567890

5.1 Tone-of-Voice Overview

The Civic Scholars Academy voice reflects the core values of intellectual rigor, youthful energy, and unwavering clarity. Our tone is confident but not arrogant, smart but accessible, and aspirational without pressure. We speak to both parents and students — often simultaneously — so our voice must bridge generations: guiding, inspiring, and educating without condescension or complexity for complexity's sake.

We are the calm expert, the strategic mentor, and the motivated teammate. We don't shout. We don't oversell. We don't talk down.

Our tone should feel:

Intelligent – precise, thoughtful language with clear purpose.

Warmly Professional – polished but not robotic; conversational without being casual.

Encouraging – belief in the potential of every student, communicated through supportive, positive framing.

Culturally aware and modern – no outdated references or jargon that isolates younger audiences.

Direct and honest – cut through clutter, especially when explaining process, expectations, or outcomes.

5.2 Tone-of-Voice by Audience

For Parents:

"We know that every child's path is unique. That's why we combine personalized instruction with proven strategies — to build confidence, sharpen skills, and help your student thrive."

For Competitive High School Students:

"You're not here to settle. You're here to improve, win rounds, and stand out. We bring the structure, coaching, and challenge you need to do exactly that."

For General Marketing Copy:

"Wherever your student starts — shy beginner or seasoned speaker — we help them find their voice, refine their thinking, and develop skills that last a lifetime."

For Certificates, Formal Letters, or Academic Recognition:

"In recognition of exemplary commitment to argumentation, inquiry, and academic excellence..."

What We Avoid:

Overly casual slang ("super pumped," "crazy good," etc.)

Empty marketing clichés ("world-class," "next-level," "game changer")

Excessive academic jargon or debate-insider terms without context

Talking at parents or students — we speak with them

5.3 Tone-of-Voice Style Grid

Content Type	Primary Audience	Tone	Language Style	Key Goals
Website Homepage	Parents & Students	Confident, Welcoming, Smart	Short, impactful sentences with active voice	Inspire trust, communicate credibility
Program Descriptions	Parents	Clear, Reassuring, Professional	Structured, benefits-focused, warm	Explain offerings & ease decision-making
Competitive Program Pages	High School Students	Bold, Motivational, Expert	Direct, high-energy, slightly informal	Signal edge and elite positioning
Email Newsletters	Parents	Friendly, Informative, Brief	Conversational tone, structured paragraphs	Build engagement and drive action
Onboarding Materials	Parents & Students	Supportive, Helpful, Calm	Step-by-step, instructional but friendly	Reduce anxiety, ensure clarity
Certificates & Awards	Parents, Institutions	Formal, Celebratory, Academic	Full sentences, traditional phrasing	Emphasize legitimacy and prestige
Social Media Posts	Students & Parents	Energetic, Smart, Relatable	Punchy headlines, confident calls to action	Drive engagement & visibility
Sales/Consultation Scripts	Parents	Trusted Advisor, Confident, Warm	Clear, persuasive, customized	Build rapport, highlight value
Ad Copy (Digital/Print)	Parents & Students	Aspirational, Crisp, Clear	Snappy headlines, clean benefits	Capture attention, drive conversions
Curriculum Materials	Students	Focused, Encouraging, Authoritative	Structured, concise, accessible	Reinforce instruction, aid learning